Heyr himna smiður

Icelandic diction guide for singers · Text: Kolbeinn Tumason (1208) · IPA for modern sung Icelandic

Stanza 1

TEXT	IPA	TRANSLATION
Heyr himna smiður	[heiːr ˈhɪmna ˈsmɪːðʏr]	*Hear, smith of heaven,*
hvers skáldið biður.	[kʰvɛr̥s ˈskaultɪð ˈpɪːðʏr]	*what the poet asks.*
Komi mjúk til mín	[ˈkʰɔːmɪ mjuːk tʰɪl miːn]	*May it come softly to me,*
miskunnin þín.	[ˈmɪskʏnɪn θiːn]	*your mercy.*
Því heit eg á þig,	[θviː heiːt ɛːɣ auː θɪːɣ]	*So I call on you,*
þú hefur skaptan mig.	[θuː ˈhɛːvʏr ˈskaftan mɪːɣ]	*you have created me.*
Eg er þrællinn þinn,	[ɛːɣ ɛːr ˈθraitlɪn θɪnː]	*I am your servant,*
þú ert Dróttinn minn.	[θuː ɛr̥t ˈtrouhtɪn mɪnː]	*you are my Lord.*

Stanza 2

TEXT	IPA	TRANSLATION
Guð, heit eg á þig	[kvʏːð heiːt ɛːɣ auː θɪːɣ]	*God, I call on you*
að þú græðir mig,	[aːð θuː ˈkraiːðɪr mɪːɣ]	*to heal me.*
minnst, mildingur, mín,	[mɪnst ˈmɪltiŋkʏr miːn]	*Remember me, gracious one;*
mest þurfum þín.	[mɛst ˈθʏrvʏm θiːn]	*I need you most.*
Ryð þú, röðla gramur,	[rɪːð θuː ˈrœðla ˈkraːmʏr]	*Drive out, king of suns,*
ríklyndur og framur,	[ˈriːklɪntʏr ɔːɣ ˈfraːmʏr]	*mighty and great,*
hölds hverri sorg	[hœlts ˈkʰvɛrːɪ sɔrk]	*every human sorrow*
úr hjarta borg.	[uːr ˈçar̥ta pɔrk]	*from the city of the heart.*

Stanza 3

TEXT	IPA	TRANSLATION
Gæt, mildingur, mín,	[kaiːt ˈmɪltiŋkʏr miːn]	*Watch over me, gracious one;*
mest þurfum þín	[mɛst ˈθʏrvʏm θiːn]	*I need you most,*
helst hverja stund	[hɛlst ˈkʰvɛrja stʏnt]	*above all every hour*
á hölða grund.	[auː ˈhœlða krʏnt]	*on the earth of men.*
Set, meyjar mögur,	[sɛːt ˈmeijar ˈmœːɣʏr]	*Place, son of the Virgin,*
málsefni fögur,	[ˈmaulsɛpnɪ ˈfœːɣʏr]	*fair thoughts (good counsel);*
öll er hjálp af þér,	[œtl ɛːr çauˌlp aːv θjɛːr]	*all help comes from you,*
í hjarta mér.	[iː ˈçaɾˌta mjɛːr]	*in my heart.*

Coaching Notes

- **Diphthongs:** *á* = [au], *æ* = [ai], *ó* = [ou], *ey/ei* = [ei], *é* = [jɛ]. Sustain the first element; close to the second late.
- **b, d, g** are unaspirated and voiceless (*biður* [p], *Dróttinn* [t], *Guð* [k]) — a soft, “lazy” p/t/k, not voiced b/d/g. **Initial p, t, k** are aspirated (*Komi*, *til*).
- **ll = [tl]**: *þrællinn*, *öll*. The classic giveaway of non-native Icelandic — drill it.
- **Pre-aspiration:** *Dróttinn* takes a light breath before the t: [ou**h**t].
- **hv = [kʰv]** (*hvers*, *hverri*). **hj = [ç]**, as in German *ich* (*hjarta*, *hjálp*).
- **þ = [θ]** (*thin*); **ð = [ð]** (*this*). Keep ð soft — never a d.
- **g** between vowels or word-final = [ɣ], a soft fricative (*þig*, *mig*, *eg*, *mögur*). Final **-rg** = [rk] (*sorg*, *borg*).
- **Clusters:** *pt* = [ft] (*skaptan*); *fn* = [pn] (*málsefni*); *ld* = [lt] (*skáldið*, *mildingur*); *nd* = [nt] (*stund*, *grund*); *ng* = [ŋk] with closed [i] (*mildingur*).
- **r** is flipped or trilled, never retroflex; it devoices before voiceless consonants (*hvers*, *ert*, *hjarta*).
- **ö** = [œ], as in French *peur*. **u** = [ʏ], as in German *Glück*. Short **y/i** = [ɪ].
- **Eg** is the older spelling, sung [ɛːɣ] — not modern *ég* [jɛːɣ].